9:56 P.M.

September 24, 2026. 9:56 p.m.

I had just finished *My Hero Academia*.

I started it on September 14.

Eleven days.

Eight seasons. Four movies.

I still do not really know how I managed that.

At some point, watching it stopped being something I did after everything else. I watched in the afternoon. I watched at night. I watched when I probably should have been doing something else. I would finish an episode, look at the time, decide that I should stop, and then watch the next one anyway. There was always one more episode that seemed harmless enough.

Then suddenly I was in Season Six.

Then Seven.

Then the Final Season.

Eleven days is a ridiculous amount of time in which to fit all of that. It did not feel ridiculous while I was doing it.

It felt normal.

For eleven days, I always knew where I was going next.

U.A. A training camp. A hospital. A school festival. A ruined city. Someone getting hurt. Someone showing up. Someone I had disliked three episodes earlier suddenly becoming a person I was worried about.

And then, at 9:56 p.m., there was no next episode.

That was it.

I remember staring at the screen for a while, although I could not tell you how long. The credits had ended. The player had already begun offering me other things to watch. My room was exactly the same room it had been before the episode started, which somehow felt wrong.

So I did the obvious thing.

I went back to YouTube and watched other people watch *My Hero Academia*.

For hours.

This made very little sense. I had literally just finished the show. I knew what happened. I knew who lived, who died, what happened to One For All, what happened to All Might, what happened eight years later. There was no information left for a reaction video to give me.

I kept clicking anyway.

Some of them annoyed me.

Someone would laugh during a scene that had made me sit completely still.

Someone would start talking over a line I had wanted to hear.

Then, every so often, somebody would just stop talking.

Those were the videos I stayed for.

I did not know why.

There were things from the last eleven days that had lodged in my head with embarrassing precision. Not necessarily the biggest fights. Not even always the scenes I would have called my favorites.

A blue lunch cloth covered in little white rabbits and orange carrots.

Eri smiling.

A melody reaching a particular point and, somehow, making several different scenes appear in my head at once.

All Might standing in front of All For One when there was almost nothing left of the All Might I had met eleven days earlier.

And, stupidly, Shinso.

He finally made it into Class 2-A, and I still wanted to see what his first ordinary morning there actually looked like.

That one bothers me more than it should.

Maybe all of this bothered me more than it should.

But by then I had stopped caring about whether it should.

I kept scrolling.

Some of the videos were from 2022.

Some from 2019.

People were sitting in rooms years ago worrying about things I had learned the answers to yesterday. They had waited months between seasons. Years, sometimes. The gap between two scenes that had been separated by three hours of my life had once been separated by an entire year of theirs.

That was when the eleven days began to feel strange.

On September 14, I had pressed play on Episode One.

On September 24, at 9:56 p.m., I had somehow arrived at the end of a story other people had spent nearly ten years waiting through.

And I still did not feel finished with it.

I. The Waiting I Skipped

The first season aired in 2016.

I was not watching it.

Afterward, I kept noticing dates.

They sat underneath old reaction videos in a place I normally would not have cared about: 2019. 2022. Sometimes earlier. I would be halfway through watching somebody react to a scene I had seen two nights ago and suddenly remember that, for the person on my screen, it had happened years ago.

They did not know what I knew.

Obviously.

Even writing that feels a little stupid. Of course somebody watching an episode years ago did not know how the series ended. But while I was watching those videos, the obviousness of it somehow made it stranger rather than less strange.

They could still guess wrong.

They could worry about somebody whose ending I already knew, or spend ten minutes arguing about a question that had lasted about twenty-three minutes for me. Then the video would end and, depending on when it had been uploaded, the answer might still have been months away.

I never had that.

If an episode ended at midnight, I could know what happened next at 12:23.

If a season ended, there was another season sitting underneath it.

I pressed “Next Episode.”

That was my timeskip.

This did not feel particularly insane while I was doing it. That might be the strangest part. I never felt as if I were racing through ten years of television. The show felt like it was moving at the correct speed; the rest of the day was what kept getting in the way.

I had Wednesday. I had Thursday. I had three episodes before dinner. I had “one more” late at night, followed by another “one more” that I already knew was a lie.

There were days when I would look at how far I had moved through a season and realize that people once had to wait a week between episodes I had put less than a minute between.

A whole year could disappear because I was not hungry enough to stop yet.

And somehow none of that made the characters feel new.

That still bothers me.

I had known All Might for eleven days. Less than two weeks. Yet by the end I could think about something as stupidly small as the cloth around a lunch he had made for Deku and immediately feel awful.

Then there was Shinso. I met him, watched him spend what felt like forever trying to get into the Hero Course, saw him finally make it—and almost immediately became annoyed that I was not going to see what his ordinary second year actually looked like.

I am aware that I had known him for a few days.

That did not seem to matter.

Maybe eleven days is simply long enough for familiarity if you spend enough of each day in the same place. Or maybe stories are allowed to cheat at this in ways real life is not.

I am not sure.

I only know that, by the time I finished, Season One already felt farther away than September 14 had any right to feel.

Music made the problem worse.

There is a track called "You Say Run." I am almost certain I had heard it somewhere before I watched *My Hero Academia*, although I no longer know where. Probably an edit, or some video that had nothing to do with the series. It is one of those songs that escaped its source long before I got there.

Inside the show, though, I understood it immediately.

At first it meant almost nothing complicated to me.

Move.

Deku runs. Somebody needs help. Something impossible is about to become slightly less impossible. The music rises and I know exactly what I am supposed to feel, and for a while I was perfectly happy to feel it.

That fit the early story too.

Deku begins with nothing. Then he gets One For All. Then he can use a little of it, then a little more. There is another percentage, another technique, another injury, another version of himself that he has not reached yet.

For a long time, everything points in the same direction.

Forward.

After I finished the series, I played “You Say Run” again and found that I could no longer keep it there.

I would hear the beginning and something from much later would show up in my head—All Might, One For All near the end, sometimes a scene I had not even thought was particularly sad when I first watched it.

That irritated me a little.

I wanted the song to sound the way it had sounded a week earlier.

It did not.

Or, more accurately, it sounded exactly the same, and that was the problem.

Once I knew the ending, I could not make the beginning innocent again. I could replay Episode One. I could not watch it without knowing what happened to the power All Might was about to give away. I could go back to an early scene and find that something from six seasons later had somehow got into it.

Sometimes I could identify exactly what had changed the scene for me. Other times I just knew that it no longer felt the same.

That was part of what I kept finding in old reaction videos: people whose version of the story had not yet been contaminated by the parts that came later.

They still had uncertainty.

I had spoilers from my own memory.

There was another difference that took me longer to notice.

The old videos themselves looked old.

Not dramatically. I was not studying them like archaeological material. But sometimes a room was different in a later upload, or somebody looked younger than I had expected, or the quality of the video itself made the date underneath it feel more real.

I do not remember every example now. Some of those hours have already blurred together with the eleven days before them.

The dates have not. A video from 2019 is still from 2019, one from 2022 still from 2022, and those numbers sit very badly next to my own memory.

Something that aired in 2019 might belong, in my head, to Tuesday. Something from 2022 might feel like yesterday.

That is an absurd compression of time, but I do not know another way to describe what happened.

Other people had seasons separated by parts of their lives. They had time to finish school years, change rooms, get older, stop caring and start caring again. They could spend months with a question unanswered.

I had autoplay.

I had eleven days in which everyone could still change enough that I missed who they had been at the beginning.

On September 14, I did not know Eri.

By September 24, I was thinking about her grown up.

On September 14, All Might was mostly an enormous smiling man who entered a scene and made everything feel solvable.

By the end, even thinking about him had become difficult.

And One For All had moved from being the thing I was waiting for Deku to receive to something I had already watched him lose.

I know those are fictional events. I know I did not literally spend years with any of them.

But memory does not seem especially interested in that distinction.

When I think about the beginning now, it does not feel like something I watched last week.

It feels earlier than that.

Maybe that was what I was trying to recover when I kept clicking on videos dated years before I had started watching. I already knew the plot. What I did not have were the months in which a theory could remain a theory, the year in which a season finale actually had to stay a finale, or all the empty space in between, when a character could remain exactly where an episode had left them because there was nothing anyone could do except wait.

I had none of those spaces.

From September 14 through September 24, I moved straight through them.

And somewhere inside those eleven days, ten years disappeared.

II. The Rabbit Cloth

There is a blue cloth covered in little white rabbits and orange carrots.

I wish I remembered some of the fights this clearly.

I do remember them. All Might throwing punches hard enough to change the weather. Kamino. The last of One For All burning out of him. The first time that enormous body collapsed into the thin man underneath it.

But when I think about All Might now, one of the first things that comes back is that cloth.

He had wrapped Deku's lunch in it.

By then, he could not do very much for him.

At the beginning, that would have sounded impossible.

All Might was the person who could do almost anything. That was basically the arrangement. He appeared, smiled, and the scale of whatever problem was happening immediately changed.

He gave Deku One For All.

Before that, he gave him something even simpler: permission to believe that his life had not already been decided by the fact that he was Quirkless.

Then he trained him. Watched him break his fingers over and over. Worried about him. Gave bad advice sometimes. Tried again.

Meanwhile his own body kept getting worse.

I knew that from the beginning, technically. The thin version of All Might was there almost immediately. Muscle, smoke, then suddenly this exhausted-looking man with sunken eyes who occasionally coughed blood.

At first the contrast was almost funny.

It was so extreme that I treated it like part of the character design. Here was the Symbol of Peace, and here was the body he had to return to when the performance ended.

Somewhere along the way I stopped waiting for him to turn big again.

I started watching the thin one.

By the time Deku left U.A., All Might could not follow him into battle the way he once would have.

He followed him anyway.

He could not take One For All back. He could not force Deku to rest. **He could not make Deku stop believing everyone around him would be safer if he disappeared.**

So he brought him food.

That is the part I keep thinking about.

Not a final attack.

Lunch.

A middle-aged man made food for a teenager who was running himself into the ground, wrapped it in a blue cloth full of rabbits and carrots, and went after him.

Then Deku left.

I understood why almost immediately, which did not help.

He was trying to keep All Might away from danger. By then, Deku had become so frightened of other people being hurt because of him that even being cared for started to look like something dangerous.

So he moved on.

And the lunch fell.

I wanted him to turn around.

That was basically my entire reaction.

Just turn around.

Take the food.

Let him do this one thing.

The cloth made it worse.

If it had been some plain black lunch bag, I probably still would have hated the scene. But it was not. It was blue and covered all over with those little rabbits and carrots, which is such a ridiculous thing to remember from a series full of explosions.

Someone had bought that cloth.

All Might owned it.

Maybe he liked it. Maybe he did not think about it at all. I honestly do not know which possibility I prefer.

There is something very strange about realizing that the Symbol of Peace apparently had ordinary objects in his life.

Of course he did.

He had to eat. He had clothes. He had a home. He had things sitting in cupboards somewhere.

But the story had trained me to think about him on a scale where those things almost disappeared.

All Might was a smile people could see from far away.

He was news footage.

He was the shape that appeared when somebody needed to believe the situation was still salvageable.

Then suddenly I was looking at his lunch cloth.

The bigger version of him had spent years convincing people that his presence was enough.

I am here.

When All Might arrived, that used to mean something almost physical. The atmosphere changed. People stopped panicking. Villains started losing.

By the time he was following Deku around with food, arriving was no longer enough.

He could be there and still not be able to stop him.

That hurt in a way the big fights usually did not.

Deku did not need a better punch from him anymore.

He did not need somebody to stand in front of him and defeat the enemy.

He needed to eat.

All Might could make food.

So he made food.

I think one reason I became so attached to him near the end is that he was obviously not very good at becoming someone who could no longer solve everything.

He had spent most of his adult life being useful on a completely unreasonable scale.

A city needed him.

The country needed him.

People built their sense of safety around whether he was still standing.

Then One For All was gone, and life did not stop.

Other heroes kept working.

Deku kept getting stronger.

The disasters became worse.

All Might remained.

He researched things. Followed Deku around. Took notes. Tried to advise him. Worried constantly. Sometimes all he seemed able to do was watch.

There was something uncomfortable about that.

Not because he had become useless. I do not think he had.

He just no longer knew how to be useful in the way he had understood usefulness for decades.

And I kept wanting him to be allowed to stop proving it.

That feeling got much worse when he went to fight All For One again.

By then I had already watched his body take enough damage for one lifetime.

One For All was gone.

His old form was gone.

All For One was very much not gone.

And there All Might was anyway.

Armor this time.

Technology.

A ridiculous collection of equipment based on the abilities of his students.

I should have been thrilled.

Part of me was.

Another part of me spent the whole thing feeling sick.

I remember thinking: please do not make me watch this man die.

Then, almost immediately after that: why are you even here?

Not in an angry way.

More like I wanted to grab him by the shoulders and tell him that nobody had asked for another proof.

He had already done it.

He had already stood in front of All For One.

He had already lost his power.

He had already passed it on.

He had already kept teaching afterward.

He did not need one more scene to convince me he was brave.

I wanted him to go home.

That would have been an insane thing for me to say about All Might when I started the series.

In the first few seasons, every time things got bad, I wanted him to appear.

By the end, every time he appeared near a battlefield, I wanted someone else to handle it.

At some point the part of him I was most afraid to lose had stopped being the part that could win fights.

I did not notice exactly when that happened.

Maybe around Kamino.

Maybe later.

Maybe there was not one moment.

I only know that by the end, “All Might” and Toshinori Yagi did not feel interchangeable to me anymore.

All Might was still there. I never started thinking the enormous smiling version was fake.

But Toshinori was the one I worried about.

Toshinori coughed blood.

Toshinori followed Deku even when he could not keep up.

Toshinori apparently owned a cloth covered in rabbits.

Toshinori made lunch.

And then Deku lost One For All too.

The first time I saw that, I thought it was sad.

I still do.

But All Might had already made it difficult for me to treat losing power as the same thing as losing the rest of a person.

He had lost One For All and stayed.

Not cleanly.

Not happily.

What I understand much better is the lunch.

That is the stupid part.

Of everything he gave Deku, the thing I keep returning to is the thing that did not work.

Deku did not stop.

He did not eat it.

The lunch ended up on the ground.

Nothing was fixed.

I can still see the blue cloth in my head.

Little white rabbits.

Orange carrots.

Food All Might had made for him.

By then, he could no longer give Deku One For All.

He could still make him lunch.

III. What We Give Away

The first time Deku tried to save Bakugo, he did not have One For All.

I think that matters more to me now than it did when I watched it.

At the time, I was mostly waiting for the story to begin properly. Deku was still Quirkless. All Might had not trained him yet. There were no percentages to keep track of, no extra abilities, no costume that looked remotely functional. Bakugo was trapped inside the sludge villain, pro heroes were standing around trying to figure out what to do, and Deku ran in.

He did not have a plan.

His body moved before he had finished thinking.

He threw himself into a situation in which, realistically, he could contribute almost nothing.

That was why All Might chose him.

I knew this, obviously. The series says it almost immediately. But after eight seasons, I had gotten so used to thinking of Deku through One For All that I had almost reversed the order in my head. He became someone who saved people because he had been given this enormous power.

That was not what happened.

He was given the power because he had already tried.

Before there was anything in his hand, he reached.

Hands show up a lot in *My Hero Academia*.

I did not notice that at first, and I am slightly suspicious of myself whenever I begin noticing something like this. There is always a danger of turning a story into an English class against its will: find an image, call it a symbol, start circling things.

But eventually the hands became difficult to ignore.

There is Bakugo, years earlier, falling and seeing Deku offer him a hand. Deku means exactly what he appears to mean.

Are you okay?

Do you need help?

Bakugo hates it.

That bothered him for years.

The hand does not change. What changes is what Bakugo thinks it means: pity, superiority, an insult.

Then there is Tenko.

A child walking around alone, visibly not okay, waiting for an adult to stop.

People notice him. They assume somebody else will handle it. Nobody reaches.

By the time somebody finally does, it is All For One.

That fact became much harder to forget near the end, because by then Deku had developed almost the opposite problem. He had spent so long running toward people that, once the danger became attached to him, he decided the kindest thing he could do was make himself impossible to reach.

He left U.A.

He stopped resting properly, stopped eating properly, and kept moving. People tried to follow him and he kept finding reasons why they should not.

It made sense.

That was the irritating part.

I understood exactly why he thought he was protecting them.

I also wanted somebody to grab him.

Eventually Iida did.

Literally.

Deku was already moving away again when Iida reached him and held on.

I had watched Deku spend season after season becoming the person who arrived for somebody else. Suddenly the direction reversed. The person being saved was the one who had built his entire identity around saving people.

He did not become weaker because somebody caught him.

It just took him an unreasonable amount of time to accept that.

By the final battle, the image had changed again.

Deku sees the child still buried somewhere inside Shigaraki.

Tenko.

And once he sees him, the problem becomes impossible in exactly the way Deku seems to prefer his problems.

Defeating Shigaraki is no longer enough.

He wants to reach him.

I was not entirely convinced this was possible. For a while I was not even sure I wanted the story to insist on it as strongly as Deku did. Too many people were already dead. Too much had happened. There is a point at which “I want to save him” starts sounding almost offensive to everyone who could not be saved from him.

Deku knows that too.

He reaches anyway.

That is the part I keep coming back to. It is not forgiveness, and it does not make the damage disappear. It is just somebody reaching for a person who may already be too far gone to reach back.

Near the end, the story gives the same basic action to somebody ordinary. Another child is alone. Another adult could keep walking.

This time, she does not.

I do not think that fixes Tenko.

It cannot.

It happens too late and to somebody else.

Maybe that is why I like it. The story does not get to go backward and put the correct hand in the correct place. It can only let somebody reach sooner the next time.

Then there was Monoma.

For several seasons, I mostly knew Neito Monoma as the loud boy from Class 1-B who seemed physically incapable of seeing Class 1-A without starting something.

He annoyed me.

That was basically his function in my head.

Then the final war started, and suddenly I wanted him to keep talking.

I had spent the first war watching Aizawa get destroyed trying to keep Erasure active.

He loses an eye.

He cuts off his own leg before the Quirk-destroying drug can spread.

By the end of it, he is alive, but the story has made very sure that being alive does not mean coming back unchanged.

I had already filed that damage away as one of the reasons the next fight with Shigaraki was going to be worse. Erasure had been one of the few abilities that could make him manageable at all. Aizawa could not simply walk into the next war as the same person.

The story did not magically repair him.

Then Monoma opened the gates.

Suddenly they were everywhere. Heroes came through them, the force that had been waiting for the final battle appearing almost at once. The plan unfolded across the battlefield before the villains could turn it back into the kind of enormous, uncontrollable fight they wanted.

The gates opened again, separating people who had arrived together. Shigaraki went to U.A. The war broke apart.

That was such a satisfying answer that I remember almost laughing.

Of course.

Copy.

The Quirk that had spent so much of the series sounding secondary by definition.

Monoma could not walk into an empty room and become powerful by himself. He needed somebody else's Quirk first. Even the way people talked about his ability had always carried this idea that it belonged to a supporting character.

Fine.

So they gave the supporting character Kurogiri.

He moved an army.

Then they gave him Aizawa.

He copied Erasure, and there he was at U.A., staring at Shigaraki and keeping his Quirks shut down.

I had spent several seasons watching this guy act like he had something to prove to the entire world.

For once, I thought:

Go ahead.

Talk your shit.

You have earned this.

What I liked was that none of it undid what had happened before. Aizawa's eye was still gone. His leg was still gone. Monoma did not become Aizawa, and Kurogiri's power did not somehow become his forever.

He borrowed what they could no longer use in the same way, used it for as long as he could, and then it was gone.

The gates still opened.

Shigaraki's Quirks still stayed off for as long as Monoma could keep Erasure on him.

One For All was different.

All Might gave it to Deku, and Deku spent almost the entire series learning how to hold it. Once it was his, the whole story seemed to assume that carrying it forward was the point.

That is why the second movie feels so strange to me now.

In *Heroes Rising*, Deku gives One For All to Bakugo.

The first time I watched that scene, it felt like an emergency measure so extreme that the story could only use it once. They need more power, Deku has the thing that can provide it, and so he gives it away.

I knew the series continued after the movie. That should have made the loss feel less real.

It did not.

Deku did not make the decision with my knowledge.

As far as he was concerned, he was giving up the thing he had spent years trying to become worthy of carrying.

Then “Might+U” starts.

I still have trouble naming what that music does to me.

Calling it sad feels wrong.

Calling it triumphant feels worse.

The fight itself is enormous. Deku and Bakugo are throwing around a ridiculous amount of power. It should feel like one of the cleanest victory sequences in the series.

The music does not let it become that simple.

There is something almost gentle underneath it. And because Deku has already decided that One For All may be the price of this victory, the whole scene feels as if it is mourning something before it is actually gone.

They are winning.

That is exactly why it hurts.

At the time, I thought that was an exception.

Then the real ending made giving One For All away the plan.

I hated that idea almost immediately, even though I understood why they were doing it. That somehow made it more annoying.

For most of the series, One For All had been a problem of receiving. Could Deku survive it? Could he control five percent, then eight, then twenty? Could his body

catch up? Could he learn the other Quirks? Could he become the person All Might believed he could become?

For years, the answer kept moving in one direction. His control improved. The percentages went up. One holder after another had added something to the power before it reached him.

Then, near the end, that direction reversed.

Instead of figuring out how to hold more of it, Deku started giving it away.

One vestige, then another.

Something that had taken generations to build was deliberately broken apart because that was the only way to get through to Shigaraki.

I remember understanding the strategy and still thinking:

Really?

After all of that?

There is a version of the ending in my head where Deku saves everybody and still gets to keep One For All afterward, and I would be lying if I said some part of me does not still want it.

He worked so hard for it.

That is probably the least useful argument possible.

It is also the one I feel most immediately.

I think about Monoma, using Warp Gate and Erasure without ever owning either of them. I think about All Might, still there after One For All had stopped being his.

And then I think about the beginning.

Deku ran toward Bakugo with no Quirk, no plan, and nothing useful in his hands.

By the end, those hands are carrying something that began long before he was born: All Might, Nana Shimura, the people before her, all of that stored power and all of those years passed forward because the next person survived long enough to receive them.

And Deku lets it go.

I am still not sure I like watching it disappear.

The first time he reached for somebody, his hand was empty.

Near the end, it held almost everything the story had spent eight seasons giving him.

He reached anyway.

IV. The Years We Didn't See

Shinso made it into the Hero Course.

I had been waiting for that.

Not for eight years, obviously.

For me it had been a few days.

Still, I had watched him show up at the Sports Festival with a Quirk that sounded almost perfect for a villain and an expression that suggested he was already tired of hearing people say so. I watched him lose to Deku. I watched Aizawa train him. I watched him come back during the joint training looking noticeably more capable and considerably less like somebody who had wandered into the wrong part of the school.

Then they told him he was transferring into the Hero Course.

Good.

Finally.

Later, after Aoyama left, Shinso would join Class 2-A. I knew that much.

What I wanted to see was what happened after that.

What was the first morning like when he walked into a room he had spent so long trying to earn his way into? Who talked to him first? Did everybody make a big deal out of it? Did they stop caring after three days? Did he?

I wanted something boring.

The story had spent all that time making his arrival matter, and then the future came so quickly that I barely got to watch him arrive.

This happens a lot near the end.

The war finishes. People survive. Buildings get rebuilt. School continues.

Then time starts moving in larger pieces.

Second year. Third year. Graduation. Later. Eight years later.

Those are not small words.

A school year is a very long time when you are actually inside one. I have had school years that seemed incapable of ending. A story can put one sentence over the whole thing.

Everybody moved up a grade.

Done.

There must have been mornings and tests and training exercises where nobody nearly died. Bad lunches. Arguments that lasted an afternoon and did not become part of anybody's character arc. Somebody forgot homework. Someone fell asleep. A class ended five minutes early.

Maybe Shinso complained about something.

Maybe Kaminari annoyed him.

I do not know.

Near the end, I started missing the things that apparently were not important enough to happen on screen.

I think that is part of why the School Festival stayed with me so much.

There is a version of *My Hero Academia* preserved there that feels almost impossibly safe now.

Not actually safe. People had already been hurt. All Might had already retired. Eri had already gone through something that I do not particularly enjoy thinking about.

But for a while, the problem was a school festival.

A concert.

Getting the timing right.

Making sure everybody had something to do.

Trying to get one little girl to have a good day.

Eri had already been rescued by then. Technically, the heroes had succeeded. She was out. Overhaul was gone.

She still did not really know how to smile.

I remember that bothering me in a completely different way from the fight that came before it.

Saving her body had been violent and spectacular.

Making her happy required a band.

I like that.

There is something slightly ridiculous about spending so many episodes watching people train to punch harder and then reaching a point where the victory I care about is a child enjoying a concert.

When Eri finally smiles, nothing that happened to her disappears.

She just gets to be happy for a while for a reason that has nothing to do with what happened before.

That was enough for me.

Then there is “Shout Baby.”

That song hurts me in a way I still do not completely understand. Part of it is when it plays. Part of it is the photographs.

There is one image I keep coming back to: Aizawa as a student, standing with people who are still just classmates in the photograph.

He looks younger in the obvious way, but that is not really what gets me.

It is just a school photograph. Nobody in it knows what I know about them yet.

That was enough to make me cry.

I remember watching those images and thinking, very seriously, that maybe this was enough.

Maybe the story could have ended around here.

I know that makes no sense.

Too much was unresolved. Shigaraki was still there. One For All was still going somewhere. Half the story had not happened yet, including some of the parts I now care about most.

I knew all of that while I was thinking it.

I still wanted it.

For a few minutes, everyone was at school.

Eri was smiling.

The students were together.

Aizawa was still mostly the tired teacher standing in front of a classroom instead of somebody I would later watch lose an eye and cut off his own leg.

All Might was still nearby.

Deku still had One For All.

Nobody had graduated.

The future had not arrived yet.

When I first heard “Shout Baby,” none of that felt like an ending.

It was just where the episode ended.

I was the one who made it into a memory later.

Deku still had One For All after the war.

For a while.

That “for a while” bothers me.

The ending tells us the embers remained and eventually disappeared. I understand why the story does not spend years showing that happen. I am not sure I would even want it to.

But I keep thinking about what it would have actually looked like.

Did he notice each time?

Was there a day when something he could do the month before became harder?

Did he know which use would be the last one?

Probably not.

I imagine it being boring.

Not some enormous final burst of light where One For All announces that it is leaving. Just less than before.

Then less again.

A school year passes. Graduation gets closer. At some point there is no fire left.

And somewhere in those same years, everybody else is becoming older in ways I do not get to watch.

Eri grows up.

Shinso becomes a normal member of the Hero Course instead of somebody trying to enter it.

The first-years stop being first-years.

Aizawa keeps teaching.

People graduate.

I do not know what most of those days looked like.

Usually when a story skips ahead, I want to know what happened because I think I missed information.

Who ended up where? Who became what? What changed?

This was different.

I knew enough.

The ending told me what I needed to know. They grew up. They became heroes. Deku became a teacher. Life continued.

What I wanted was not more information.

I wanted the missing Tuesdays.

That sounds stupid.

I mean it literally.

A Tuesday in second year when nothing happened.

A Wednesday afternoon when they trained and went home.

One of those stretches of life that feels disposable while you are living it because there will be another one tomorrow.

After I finished, I realized how little I actually wanted from the story.

I did not need another villain.

I did not need another war.

I wanted to see Shinso having an ordinary day in Class 2-A.

I wanted Deku to have One For All for one more ordinary day.

V. Friends

There is a point in “Friends,” a little after one minute, where I stop hearing a piece of music and start seeing things.

I do not really know how else to explain it.

The beginning is fine.

I like the beginning.

Then it gets to around 1:10.

Something changes.

I have listened to it enough now that I know the change is coming, which somehow does not help.

A few notes arrive and suddenly there are images.

Deku after saving Kota.

The end of the first movie.

The end of the second.

Sometimes something else gets there first.

I do not always choose.

That is the strange part.

I can sit down intending to listen to the track by itself, with no episode playing and nothing on the screen, and my brain still starts supplying footage.

Not perfectly.

I could not reconstruct every scene for you shot by shot. I am not even completely sure I could put all of them in the right order without checking.

There is one image that comes back especially easily.

The fight is over. Kota is safe. And what stays with me is Deku's figure in the still afterward, after the punching and the impact and everything that got him there.

That image comes back faster than parts of the fight itself.

Apparently my brain spent eleven days watching people smash through walls and decided this was the useful part to keep.

I am no longer arguing with it.

Then a movie ending arrives.

Then another.

They do not belong to the same part of the story. They were not released at the same time. In my head, that distinction has become strangely weak.

The music puts them beside each other anyway.

That may be the closest thing I have to what those eleven days feel like in memory now.

Everything is too close.

Season Three is not years away from the Final Season. It is a few days to the left. A movie might be another night.

Something that once belonged to one year can sit almost on top of something that belonged to another because I never had enough time between them for the memories to spread out.

I watched the series in order.

My memory did not keep the filing system.

It kept shortcuts.

“Friends” is one of them.

Around 1:10, several things seem to open at once.

I wonder what the track sounded like to me before all this.

Probably just like music.

I cannot get back there now.

I did not grow up with this soundtrack. I do not have a memory of hearing it when I was twelve and returning to it years later. There is no old bedroom attached to it, no earlier version of myself waiting somewhere inside it.

On September 13, as far as I was concerned, none of these memories existed.

Then I pressed play.

Less than two weeks later, one minute and ten seconds into a song could make me cry.

That seems unfair.

I gave everything eleven days.

Apparently that was enough.

Maybe that is why Deku's still figure and the movie endings remain so close together in my head. I never gave any of them much time to move away.

One thing arrived while the previous thing was still warm.

Now a few notes can bring several of them back at once.

There are other things I have already started forgetting.

Small pieces of dialogue. The exact order of some fights. Which episode contained something I am completely sure I watched.

That bothered me at first.

I had just finished the series.

How could it already be blurring?

Then I realized that forgetting was already choosing for me, whether I liked it or not.

I remember the rabbit cloth.

I remember wondering where Shinso sat.

And I remember 1:10.

That number is absurdly precise considering how many more important things I could not locate without looking them up.

But I know where to go.

I press play and wait for it.

The passage comes.

Before I have time to decide what I am remembering, somebody is already there.

Sometimes Deku.

Sometimes the end of a movie.

Sometimes several things so close together that I stop trying to separate them.

I am already forgetting which scenes came first and what happened around them.

But when 1:10 arrives, I usually know what I am seeing before I can name it.

VI. After the Last Episode

After the last episode, I went back to YouTube.

Again.

By then I had already watched enough reaction videos to know the routine.

Thumbnail. Episode number. Someone's face enlarged beside a character's face. A title promising that they had LOST IT or COULD NOT BELIEVE THIS or WERE NOT READY.

Click.

For a while, that was enough.

It gave me another twenty or forty minutes in which the episode was happening to somebody for the first time.

I already knew what came next.

They did not.

That difference had kept me watching before.

But after a while I started becoming annoyingly specific about what I wanted from them.

Someone would laugh during a scene that had made me stop moving. Someone would start talking exactly when I wanted them to stop. A character would say something I had been waiting several seasons to hear, and the person in the corner of the screen would shout over it.

"YO, BRO—"

Close tab.

Next video.

I knew this was unfair. They were reaction channels; reacting was the job. A person sitting completely still for thirty seconds is not necessarily excellent entertainment.

I was also watching strangers on the internet and getting irritated because they were not experiencing a television show correctly according to rules I had invented five minutes earlier.

Still.

Next video.

There was one small fantasy I had attached, somewhat embarrassingly, to the idea of going to the United States.

I had imagined anime might feel less private there. Not universal, just less like something that always had to be explained first.

Somewhere in that fantasy was the idea that recognition would come more easily.

Then I watched American reaction videos and discovered that recognition was not the same thing as agreement.

This should not have surprised me.

It did anyway.

There were people who loved *My Hero Academia* and laughed in places where I had cried. People who had followed it for years and turned moments I had found

almost unbearable into jokes. People who knew far more about the series than I did and still seemed to be watching a completely different emotional object.

For a while, this irritated me more than it had any right to.

So I tried other people.

Japanese reactions. VTubers. Channels from places I knew almost nothing about.

Some people were loud, some quiet, some made jokes and cried within five minutes of each other.

Nationality turned out not to help much. Neither did age, or how many figures somebody had on the shelf behind them.

What I was looking for was smaller than that.

There would be a scene I knew well enough to know exactly where it was going, and then the person watching would stop talking.

Sometimes their face changed first.

Sometimes a hand went over a mouth.

Sometimes they stared at the screen after the episode had already moved on.

Sometimes the credits began and they let them.

Those were the videos I stayed for.

It took me an embarrassingly long time to understand why.

I did not need somebody to tell me *My Hero Academia* was good, or a stranger on the internet to certify that a scene was officially sad.

I knew what had happened to me.

None of it became more true because somebody else cried too.

But I kept looking.

Maybe I wanted a witness.

That word feels slightly dramatic.

I cannot find a better one.

There is something uncomfortable about having a very strong reaction to something that, in the most literal sense, did not happen.

I knew that while I was crying.

It did not make me stop.

I was still sitting in a real room in front of a real screen, with a headache from watching too many episodes. The next day I could hear a piece of music and feel something happen in my chest before I had decided what I was remembering.

You too?

Here?

That was the question, I think.

It kept me scrolling for hours.

Sometimes the answer was no.

Someone would laugh. Someone would miss the line entirely. Someone would pause in the middle of the worst possible moment to explain a theory that no longer mattered.

I got less angry about this eventually.

They were not failing a test.

They had simply brought a different life to the same scene.

I had brought eleven days.

That probably mattered.

I had barely had time for one emotion to settle before another was placed on top of it. Kamino was still close when I reached things that had aired years later. The School Festival had not had time to become nostalgic before the ending made it nostalgic for me. All Might had gone from invincible to somebody I wanted protected in less than two weeks of my life.

Maybe I was raw.

Other people had watched a season, turned the television off, and lived for a year.

I had pressed Next Episode.

Still, every now and then I found someone who went quiet exactly where I had.

Those were the moments of recognition I had imagined finding somewhere much larger.

I had pictured something like a crowd. What I actually found was much smaller: a few seconds in which somebody else stopped at the same place.

By then it was late.

The show was still over.

No amount of reaction videos had changed that.

The people inside them were still fictional.

The people watching them were strangers.

Tomorrow, none of us would be in the same room.

But for a few seconds, a person years ago could stop talking in front of a screen, and I could sit in front of mine in September 2026 and understand exactly why.

Epilogue — Inheritance

September 24, 2026.

9:56 p.m.

That was when I finished *My Hero Academia*.

I remember the time because I did not know what else to do with the fact that it was over.

Across those eleven days, there had always been something next: another episode, another movie, another opening I had not heard yet, another character I did not know I would care about until, somehow, I did.

Then there was nothing to press.

Maybe that was why 9:56 felt so exact. It was the first minute that did not automatically lead somewhere else.

Other people had spent years moving through this story. I had skipped almost all of their waiting, but I could not skip what they had left behind.

The old videos, the comments, and the music were still there.

And now, I suppose, this is here too.

I do not know when I will watch the series again. Maybe soon, maybe years from now.

If I do, I already know it will not be the same eleven days. I will know where everyone ends up. I will hear the later scenes inside the earlier music. I will probably notice things I missed and forget things I was certain I would remember.

That seems fair.

The first time was always going to disappear as I was having it.

I just did not realize how quickly.

At 9:56 p.m., I thought I had reached the point where there was nothing next.

I was wrong about that.

There was just no next episode.